# The Truth About 1959 and 1966

**SECRET CANON — locked.** This is what really happened. Almost no character knows it. The Smilleys believe their version, the Donohues believe Victor's, and both are wrong. The story reveals this slowly over the course of the saga.

## The One-Paragraph Truth

Victor Donohue never stole from Cornelius Smilley, and he never fully told the truth either. Cornelius lost his fiancée because of **his own mother**, and lost his company because of **the FBI, the banks and the racism of the era**. Victor protected the company and secretly set aside everything Cornelius was owed, then let his pride bury the secret for forty years. The money is still sitting there, and it is now worth billions.

## Wound #1: Why Joan Really Left (1959)

- **Pearl Smilley paid her to go.** Joan Mercer was a sharecropper's daughter from Mississippi with dark skin and no pedigree, and Pearl decided she was not fit to be a Smilley wife. In the spring of 1959, Pearl met Joan privately, offered her **$5,000** to break off the engagement, and made it clear her family's connections could end Joan's career if she refused.
- **Joan took the money** and sent it home to pay off her family's land debt. She broke the engagement without saying why. She met Victor that winter, and their love was real. They married in 1960.
- **She never told anyone,** not Cornelius and not even Victor. She knew the truth would destroy Cornelius's love for his mother. Pearl's famous line, *"Hate is expensive, baby. Somebody always pays,"* was a confession nobody understood.
- **The irony:** Pearl caused the first wound, and the Smilleys have blamed the Donohues for it for 47 years.

## Wound #2: What Really Happened in December 1966

| When | What really happened |
|---|---|
| 1955-1960 | Cornelius raises money for the Montgomery Bus Boycott, performs at civil rights benefits, and keeps friendships from the leftist theater world. **The FBI opens a file on him**, as it really did on many politically active Black entertainers. Agents quietly visit his employers. |
| 1959-1966 | After losing Joan, and with the FBI pressure building, **Cornelius starts drinking**. He misses meetings. *This part of Victor's story is true.* |
| 1964-1966 | Smilley-Donohue Productions has a hit, but heavy debts on its follow-up. The Smilley Fund is the label's main collateral. |
| Dec 15, 1966 | Gus Donohue dies. Donohue Entertainment is in the middle of financing its enormous Florida project, the future Donohue World. |
| Dec 1966 | **The ultimatum.** The company's lead banker on the board, **Harrison Whitcomb**, delivers terms from the lenders: the FBI has "advised" the banks about Cornelius Smilley. Victor can become CEO and the credit lines stay open only if the company cuts all ties with Cornelius at once. Otherwise the loans are called, the Florida project dies, and thousands of jobs go with it. |
| Dec 30, 1966 | **Victor's choice.** He takes the deal. Smilley-Donohue Productions is folded into Donohue at the bank's lowball valuation, and Cornelius is bought out. **That same night**, Victor secretly creates an irrevocable trust holding Donohue shares equal to the true value of Cornelius's stake plus the entire Smilley Fund. He names it the **Rooftop Trust**, after their 1958 photograph. |
| Dec 31, 1966 | Victor writes Cornelius a six-page letter explaining everything: the FBI, the ultimatum, the trust. He plans to hand it over once the lenders are satisfied. |

| When | What really happened |
|---|---|
| Feb 1967 | Before Victor can deliver it, Cornelius sues him and calls him a thief in *Jet* magazine. Victor's pride takes over: *"If he wants to call me a thief in public, he can wait for my funeral to learn the truth."* The letter goes into a safe-deposit box. |
| 1967-2006 | The lawsuit, Zeke's 1979 Oath, Robert's 1989 quote and Natasha's 1997 raid each make silence easier and confession harder. The trust keeps growing. |

## The Rooftop Trust (April 2006)

| Detail | Fact |
|---|---|
| Holdings | Donohue Class A shares, about **0.45% of the company**, worth about **$6.75 billion** |
| Terms | It vests on **Victor's death** and is divided equally among Cornelius Smilley's living direct descendants at that moment. If Cornelius is alive, he gets a lifetime share as well. |
| Trustees | Joan Donohue and the family's attorney, **Leland Brooks** (born 1930, age 76 today), a Black lawyer who has kept the secret for forty years |
| Who knows | **Victor, Joan and Leland Brooks. That's all.** Not Natasha, not Robert, not Cornelius, Hattie or Desmond. Joan also keeps the letter and the rooftop photo. |
| The bombshell | Any child of Esther's is Cornelius's direct descendant. From May 10, 2012, **Emma and Victoria Bullock, Marc-Anthony's daughters, are beneficiaries of the Smilley fortune Desmond thinks the Donohues stole.** |

## Who Was Right?

- **The Smilleys' version** ("Victor stole our company and Joan"): emotionally true, factually wrong.
- **Victor's version** ("Cornelius was drinking; I saved the company"): factually true and deeply incomplete. He leaves out the FBI, the ultimatum and the trust, out of shame and pride.
- **The real villains:** the FBI's surveillance of Black activists, the banks that gave in to it, Pearl's colorism and class snobbery, and two proud men who loved each other and never said so.

**Suggested reveal path (not locked):** small hints first (the rooftop photo in both men's homes, Leland Brooks at Smilley events). Simone finds out about Pearl's payment. Joan reveals the letter to Esther and Marc-Anthony. Then Cornelius learns the truth, and finally Desmond, the man whose whole identity rests on the lie. You decide when each reveal happens.